

# fp-tools: A Reproducible Platform for ATAC-seq Footprinting and Regulatory Motif Analysis

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## Abstract

ATAC-seq footprinting enables near-base-resolution inference of transcription-factor (TF) occupancy across the genome. However, the field lacks a computationally efficient, user-friendly, and integrated platform that accepts both bulk and single-cell ATAC-seq data, supports both de novo motif discovery and matching to public motif databases, and generates interactive and publication-ready visual outputs. Here, we present fp-tools, a Python package that builds on the widely used ATAC-seq footprinting framework TOBIAS. We substantially improve computational efficiency across key steps, including Tn5 bias correction, footprint calling, and motif matching. In addition, fp-tools introduces de novo motif discovery, replicate-aware differential footprinting, and aggregation analysis, features not provided as native TOBIAS workflows. We further streamline a single-cell ATAC-seq footprinting workflow, provide interactive visualization of analysis results, and implement a graphical user interface (GUI) that enables code-free execution of all package commands. Using public bulk ATAC-seq replicates and single-cell datasets, we demonstrate that fp-tools quantitatively recovers cell-type-specific TF-binding patterns and identifies de novo binding motifs that are not captured by existing public motif databases. Together, fp-tools provides an efficient, accessible, and comprehensive platform for TF footprint analysis across bulk and single-cell ATAC-seq studies.

**Keywords:** ATAC-seq; transcription factor footprinting; chromatin accessibility; motif analysis; pseudobulk ATAC-seq; replicate-aware reporting; reproducibility; command-line bioinformatics

## 1. Introduction

Chromatin accessibility profiling by the assay for transposase-accessible chromatin using sequencing (ATAC-seq) has become a standard readout of active regulatory DNA [1]. Within accessible regions, sequence-specific transcription factors (TFs) can protect bound DNA from transposition, producing local cut-site depletions, or “footprints,” with increased accessibility in nearby flanks. Detecting these motif-centered cut-site patterns supports inference of TF occupancy, differential regulatory activity between conditions, and interpretation of non-coding regulatory variants. Earlier footprinting and occupancy models, including CENTIPEDE, Wellington, PIQ, and DeFCoM, established the value of combining sequence information with chromatin accessibility profile shape for TF-binding-site inference [2–5].

Despite this progress, practical ATAC-seq footprinting remains difficult to run as a complete and reproducible analysis. Widely used tools such as TOBIAS [6] and HINT-ATAC [7] provide enzymatic bias correction and footprint scoring for bulk ATAC-seq data.

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Multiscale and nucleosome-aware approaches, including the PRINT/scPrinter family [8], extend footprint modeling across different scales of chromatin protection. Supervised TF-binding-site predictors such as maxATAC [9] and sequence-to-profile models such as ChromBPNet [10] provide complementary prediction frameworks. Motif-discovery and motif-comparison tools, including MEME/STREME [11,12] and Tomtom [13], are commonly used after peak or footprint selection, and curated databases such as JASPAR [14] remain central for known-motif matching. These tools are valuable, but they are typically assembled through separate command interfaces, file conventions, report formats, and visualization steps.

This fragmentation creates a practical barrier for many applied studies. A complete analysis must connect ATAC-seq input processing, Tn5 sequence-bias correction, footprint scoring, motif matching, optional de novo motif discovery, differential footprint analysis, aggregate visualization, and publication-ready reporting. Single-cell ATAC-seq adds another difficulty: sparse per-cell fragments usually need to be aggregated into cell-type, cluster, or neighborhood-level profiles before footprinting can be interpreted. For many biology laboratories, the limiting step is therefore not one missing algorithm, but the absence of an efficient platform that connects these steps and preserves the analysis record.

We developed *fp-tools* to address this need. The package builds on the widely used TOBIAS ATAC-seq footprinting framework and keeps its interpretable motif-centered footprint logic, while improving speed and usability around the core analysis. Compared with TOBIAS, *fp-tools* adds de novo motif preparation and matching, replicate-aware differential footprint reports, pseudobulk single-cell ATAC-seq support, interactive HTML reports, editable SVG outputs, and a graphical user interface for code-free execution of the same command-compatible workflows.

Here, we describe the *fp-tools* implementation and evaluate it with public bulk ATAC-seq replicates and public single-cell ATAC-seq datasets. We focus on practical improvements to established ATAC-seq footprinting: connecting common TF-footprinting tasks into one auditable analysis that can be run from the command line, saved YAML files, or the GUI.

## 2. Materials and Methods

### 2.1. Package Architecture and Core Workflows

*fp-tools* accelerates the main signal-processing steps used in ATAC-seq footprinting. The core analysis includes Tn5 sequence-bias correction, footprint scoring over corrected signal, motif-anchored differential analysis, and aggregate visualization around TFBS or region sets. These steps use shared region, signal, motif, and sample-label conventions, so the output of one step can be used directly by the next. YAML configuration files provide a reproducible way to save and rerun the same analysis without changing the underlying methods.

Following the signal model popularized by TOBIAS [6], *fp-tools* treats base-resolution, bias-corrected cut-site profiles as the primary footprinting signal. This design preserves the familiar bulk ATAC footprinting interpretation: the biological signal is a corrected center-versus-flank cut-site contrast at motif or candidate sites. After bias correction, *fp-tools* can additionally rescale corrected cut-site tracks before footprint scoring by matching the 95th percentile of signal over shared background regions to an across-sample target, usually the median. This robust q95 scaling reduces sample-to-sample signal-level variation before footprint scoring while being less sensitive to rare extreme bins than full quantile matching. The package keeps this signal definition while recording sample labels, input manifests, reusable configuration, replicate summaries, and report outputs. For

footprint calling, let  $x_i$  denote corrected Tn5 cut-site signal around candidate position  $p$ . The default footprint score is a center-versus-flank contrast,

$$F(p) = \frac{1}{|L| + |R|} \left( \sum_{i \in L} x_i + \sum_{i \in R} x_i \right) - \frac{1}{|C|} \sum_{i \in C} x_i,$$

where  $C$  is the protected center and  $L$  and  $R$  are flanking windows. Larger values therefore correspond to the expected footprint pattern: fewer cuts at the putative bound site and more cuts in nearby accessible flanks.

## 2.2. De Novo Motif Discovery Preparation

The de novo motif-discovery module begins from candidate footprint intervals, which may be produced by footprint calling or provided as input. For each candidate interval  $j$  with center  $p_j$ , strand  $a_j$ , and flank size  $h$ , it exports a candidate-centered sequence

$$S_j = G[p_j - h, p_j + h],$$

reverse-complementing the sequence when strand information indicates the negative strand. The module records the input intervals, genome build, flank width, software versions, and MEME, DREME, STREME [11,12,15] or optional Tomtom [13] settings needed to reproduce each run. STREME was designed for accurate motif discovery from enriched sequence sets [12]. Discovered motifs can be analyzed as an independent motif set or matched to a known database such as JASPAR 2026 [14] and appended to the known motif set for downstream differential footprint analysis. In this design, candidate FASTA export, motif discovery, motif comparison, and database augmentation become part of the recorded footprint analysis.

## 2.3. Pseudobulk Fragment Aggregation

The pseudobulk module groups single-cell ATAC fragments by a metadata column, such as cell type, cluster, donor, or treatment. Let  $F_b$  be the multiset of fragments assigned to barcode  $b$ , and let  $g(b)$  be its group label. The pseudobulk fragment collection for group  $k$  is the concatenated multiset

$$F_k = \text{concat}_{b:g(b)=k}(F_b),$$

so repeated fragments and fragment multiplicity are preserved. Groups that pass specified cell-count and fragment-count filters are written as bulk-like fragment files with manifest records. When genome sizes are supplied, `fp-tools` can also emit CPM-normalized cut-site bigWigs,

$$y_{k,t} = 10^6 \frac{c_{k,t}}{\sum_u c_{k,u}},$$

where  $c_{k,t}$  is the cut-site count for group  $k$  at genomic position  $t$ . These tracks support motif-centered aggregate profiles matched to the bulk ATAC-seq analysis path. The full pseudobulk route writes pseudo-paired BAMs from grouped fragments and then runs correction, scoring, motif-aware comparison, and plotting with the same conventions used for bulk ATAC-seq.

For cell-level marker visualization, `fp-tools` also computes K-nearest-neighbor (KNN)-smoothed footprint signatures from single-cell fragments. For each marker TF, motif centers are scanned inside the selected accessible-bin universe. Fragment cut sites are counted in a  $\pm 100$  bp window around those motif centers for each barcode. Each cell is assigned a local neighborhood profile by summing its 75 nearest neighbors in the single-cell embedding, and a flank-minus-center footprint-signature score is computed from that

neighborhood profile. Scores are oriented so that the expected marker cell type has the positive direction and then standardized per TF for UMAP display. These KNN-smoothed signatures summarize local, motif-centered cut-site patterns across neighboring cells, while full ATAC-corrected footprint tracks are computed from the grouped pseudobulk profiles.

#### 2.4. Replicate-aware Differential Footprint Analysis

The differential footprint module supports both single-sample contrasts and replicate-supported comparisons. It retains conventional motif-centered footprint-score logic while adding repeated condition labels, replicate-level summaries, and replicate-aware testing. Repeated condition names, for example `-cond-names Bcell Bcell Tcell Tcell`, define biological replicate groups while preserving the original differential-footprint output structure. Let  $x_{c,r,i}$  be the footprint score at site or background position  $i$  for replicate  $r$  of condition  $c$ .

For one-sample versus one-sample contrasts, `diff-footprints` uses the motif-site versus background-distribution comparison of the standard TOBIAS-style report. Candidate sites are grouped by motif, site-level changes at motif sites are compared with matched background changes, and p-values are adjusted across motifs within each contrast.

For replicate-supported comparisons, `fp-tools` generalizes this comparison to multiple samples per condition. Footprint scores are computed for each replicate on the same peak and motif-site universe. Replicate scores are then summarized within each condition,

$$\bar{x}_{c,i} = \frac{1}{n_c} \sum_{r=1}^{n_c} x_{c,r,i}, \quad s_{c,i}^2 = \frac{1}{n_c - 1} \sum_{r=1}^{n_c} (x_{c,r,i} - \bar{x}_{c,i})^2.$$

For motif  $m$ , let  $S_m$  denote its candidate motif sites and  $B_m$  the matched background sites. The replicate-aware motif-background effect is reported as

$$\Delta_m = \frac{1}{|S_m|} \sum_{i \in S_m} (\bar{x}_{c_1,i} - \bar{x}_{c_2,i}) - \frac{1}{|B_m|} \sum_{i \in B_m} (\bar{x}_{c_1,i} - \bar{x}_{c_2,i}).$$

The report also includes replicate counts, condition means, SDs, and SE summaries, so the additional samples contribute to a more stable estimate rather than being collapsed outside the analysis.

Quantile normalization remains an optional comparison-stage adjustment. In single-sample contrasts, sample-quantile normalization provides the conventional two-sample score-distribution matching. In replicate-supported comparisons, condition-quantile normalization averages background distributions within each condition, fits one normalization factor per condition, and applies that factor to the replicates before condition summaries are computed. This option is used as a sensitivity adjustment; the main replicate-aware extension is the explicit use of replicate-level motif scores.

When per-sample motif-score matrices are available, `fp-tools` further applies empirical-Bayes variance moderation across motifs, following the moderated testing framework of Smyth [16]. This replicate-supported view estimates condition effects from the per-sample motif scores. If  $z_{c,r,m} = |S_m|^{-1} \sum_{i \in S_m} x_{c,r,i}$  is the per-sample motif score, the contrast is

$$\hat{\beta}_m = \frac{1}{n_{c_1}} \sum_r z_{c_1,r,m} - \frac{1}{n_{c_2}} \sum_r z_{c_2,r,m}, \quad t_m^{EB} = \frac{\hat{\beta}_m}{\sqrt{s_{m,EB}^2 (n_{c_1}^{-1} + n_{c_2}^{-1})}},$$

where  $s_{m,EB}^2$  is the variance moderated across motifs. Adjusted differential-footprint statistics from this view are reported alongside the native motif-background columns.



## 2.5. Public Data Processing and Evaluation

The bulk replicate demonstration uses a 3-vs-3 public ENCODE ATAC-seq comparison between K562 and HepG2, with three released GRCh38 alignment BAMs per cell line. Problematic genomic regions were filtered using the ENCODE blacklist [17]. Replicate peak intervals were merged into a common peak universe, bias-corrected, q95-scaled over shared background regions, footprint-called, and analyzed by replicate-aware differential footprint comparison. The analysis used JASPAR 2026 CORE vertebrates non-redundant motifs [14] for known-motif scanning. Exact command-line parameters and software versions are recorded in source TSV files in the manuscript tables directory and summarized in Tables S1 and S2.

Public inputs are organized as versioned TSV manifests that record source URLs, accessions, assemblies, checksums, local paths, and analysis labels. Discovery and download scripts query public repositories such as ENCODE [18] for released human GRCh38 ATAC-seq records and write resumable download reports. The manuscript evaluation combines compact regression inputs, public bulk ATAC replicates, de novo motif-preparation examples, and public PBMC single-cell ATAC examples. For each analysis, command-line parameters, software versions, resolved input manifests, source tables, and generated figure inputs are kept with the manuscript resources so the reported examples can be rerun and audited.

## 2.6. Reproducibility Engineering

The package includes unit tests for numerical helpers and CLI behavior, plus automated output checks for footprint calling, differential footprint analysis, and aggregate plotting, with an opt-in slow check for bias correction. Continuous integration runs the suite on compact reference inputs, builds source and wheel artifacts, and verifies the installed console scripts. The repository also includes `environment.yml`, a Dockerfile, release metadata, and Make targets for testing, building, and manuscript checks. These choices follow FAIR-oriented research-software principles and established bioinformatics environment practices [19–21]. Analysis scripts record random seeds, tool versions, command lines, and resolved manifests alongside the corresponding outputs. Figure source tables and editable figure files are retained with the manuscript resources for auditability.

# 3. Results

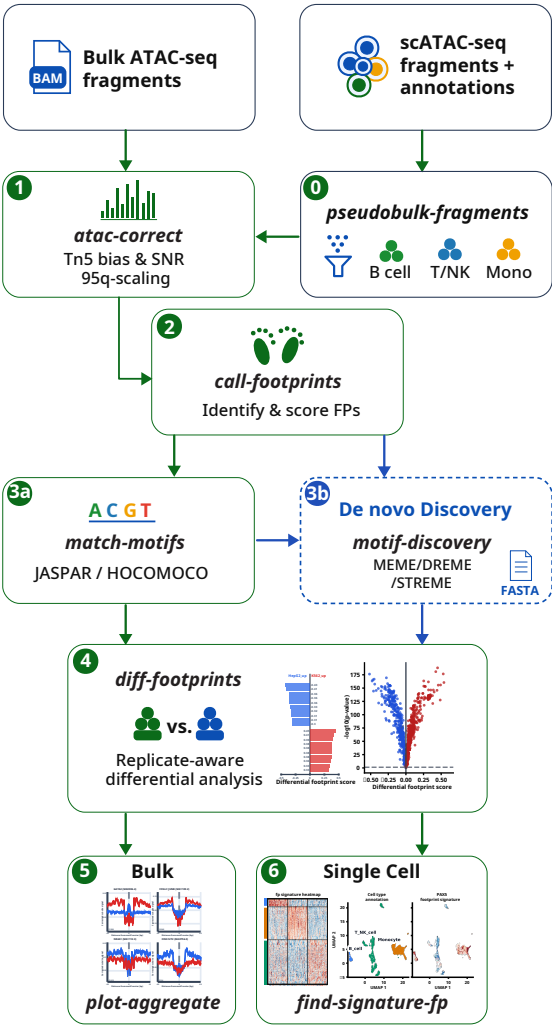
We evaluated `fp-tools` for command stability, local runtime and memory behavior, and biological plausibility in public bulk and single-cell ATAC-seq examples.

## 3.1. A Unified, Reproducible Footprinting Platform

`fp-tools` consolidates the core ATAC-seq footprinting steps into one command-compatible analysis. Bias correction, footprint calling, differential footprint analysis, and aggregate visualization share region and signal conventions, reducing the need for file-format conversion between steps. YAML configuration records the same analysis in a machine-readable form for reruns and batch processing (Figure 1).

## 3.2. Interactive Interfaces and Report Review

In addition to direct command-line execution, `fp-tools` provides browser-based interfaces for configuring analyses and reviewing results. The GUI writes reusable YAML configurations that remain compatible with command-line execution and provides guided panels for the same core commands shown in the documentation (Figure 6). Differential-footprint and aggregate-batch runs also produce self-contained HTML reports with em-



**Figure 1.** Overview of the fp-tools ATAC-seq footprinting platform. Bulk ATAC-seq BAM/fragments and single-cell ATAC fragments with annotations enter a shared command-oriented analysis. The analysis supports Tn5 bias correction, footprint calling, motif matching against curated databases, de novo motif discovery, replicate-aware differential footprint analysis, aggregate footprint visualization, and pseudobulk single-cell footprint analysis.

bedded compressed data, searchable motif controls, editable group colors, synchronized aggregate profiles, and SVG export for publication-ready editing.

3.3. Tested Output Stability

The package includes automated checks that run core commands on compact reference inputs and compare key summary outputs for footprint calling, differential footprint analysis, and aggregate plotting. Additional checks exercise public command-line entry points and saved YAML configurations. Together, these tests help ensure that updates preserve the expected behavior of the main workflows and shared input/output conventions.

3.4. De Novo Motif Discovery Complements Database-based Motif Analysis

The de novo motif-preparation path converts candidate footprint intervals into centered FASTA files, runs MEME, DREME, or STREME, optionally compares discovered motifs with a known database using Tomtom, and writes TSV/HTML summaries with inline consensus logos. This extends the TOBIAS-style known-motif path by adding a recorded handoff from footprint candidates to motif discovery; it does not change the

center-versus-flank footprint scoring model. The module can be run alone to discover recurring patterns in candidate intervals, or after known-motif scanning to find motifs that are absent from the selected database.

We used public ENCODE K562 and HepG2 ATAC-seq data as two examples to ask whether candidate footprint intervals contain recurring sequence motifs beyond a curated database. This analysis was not used as a formal condition-comparison test. Candidate footprints were called from bias-corrected cut-site tracks, candidate FASTA files were exported with 75 bp flanks, and STREME was run on candidate intervals from each cell line with the other cell line used as a sequence-control set. Discovered motifs were then summarized, compared with JASPAR by Tomtom, and scanned back into candidate intervals for aggregate footprint review.

The full JASPAR 2026 vertebrate non-redundant set contained 1019 motifs, and the reciprocal STREME runs contributed 500 candidate-derived motifs from the two ENCODE cell lines. We evaluated de novo discovery as a motif-window coverage test rather than as a differential-footprint significance test. After merging bound-site windows from the de novo scan and the corresponding JASPAR-supported scan, candidate-derived motifs recovered 84.0% of merged JASPAR-supported bound-site-window base pairs, while 16.0% remained unique to the full JASPAR scan. The de novo-only scan also introduced candidate-derived bound-site windows corresponding to 6.0% of the de novo-only merged window base pairs. These values are operational recovery summaries, not multiple-testing significance calls.

Representative discovered motifs showed clear motif-centered aggregate footprint profiles in K562 and HepG2, indicating that the de novo sequence patterns correspond to footprinted cut-site structure in the candidate intervals (Figure 2). These results support using de novo motif discovery as a complement to database-based motif matching when the chosen motif collection is incomplete or conservative.

### 3.5. Replicate-aware Differential Footprint Analysis

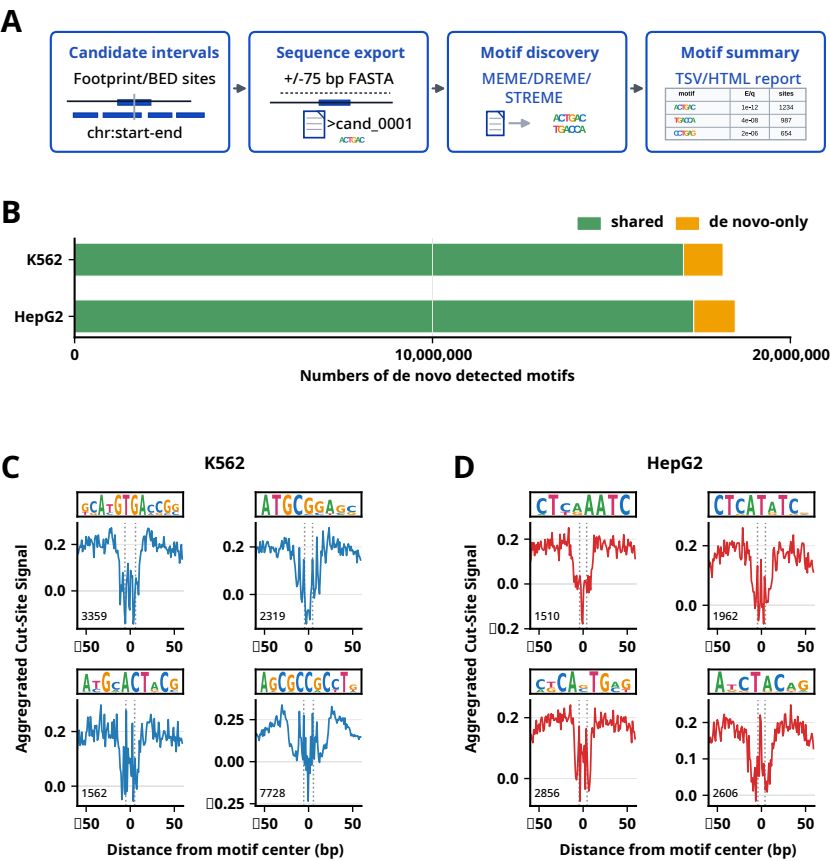
The replicate-aware analysis reports differential footprint effect sizes, replicate support, and uncertainty summaries while keeping each comparison anchored to a common peak and motif-site universe. In the K562 versus HepG2 3-vs-3 analysis, all six replicates were scanned on the merged ENCODE peak set before comparison, so no additional peak alignment step was needed at the reporting stage.

Repeated condition names define biological replicate groups. In one-sample contrasts, the report uses the motif-site versus background-distribution comparison. When multiple samples are available, motif scores are first aggregated per sample and then analyzed with empirical-Bayes variance moderation across motifs [16]. The K562/HepG2 replicate-supported output reports condition means, replicate counts, SD and SE summaries, moderated statistics, and adjusted q-values alongside the original motif-background comparison.

A representative K562 versus HepG2 differential footprint report is shown in Figure 3. The report combines selected motif logos, top differential motif rankings, a volcano summary, and replicate-level aggregate footprint profiles in one browser-review view.

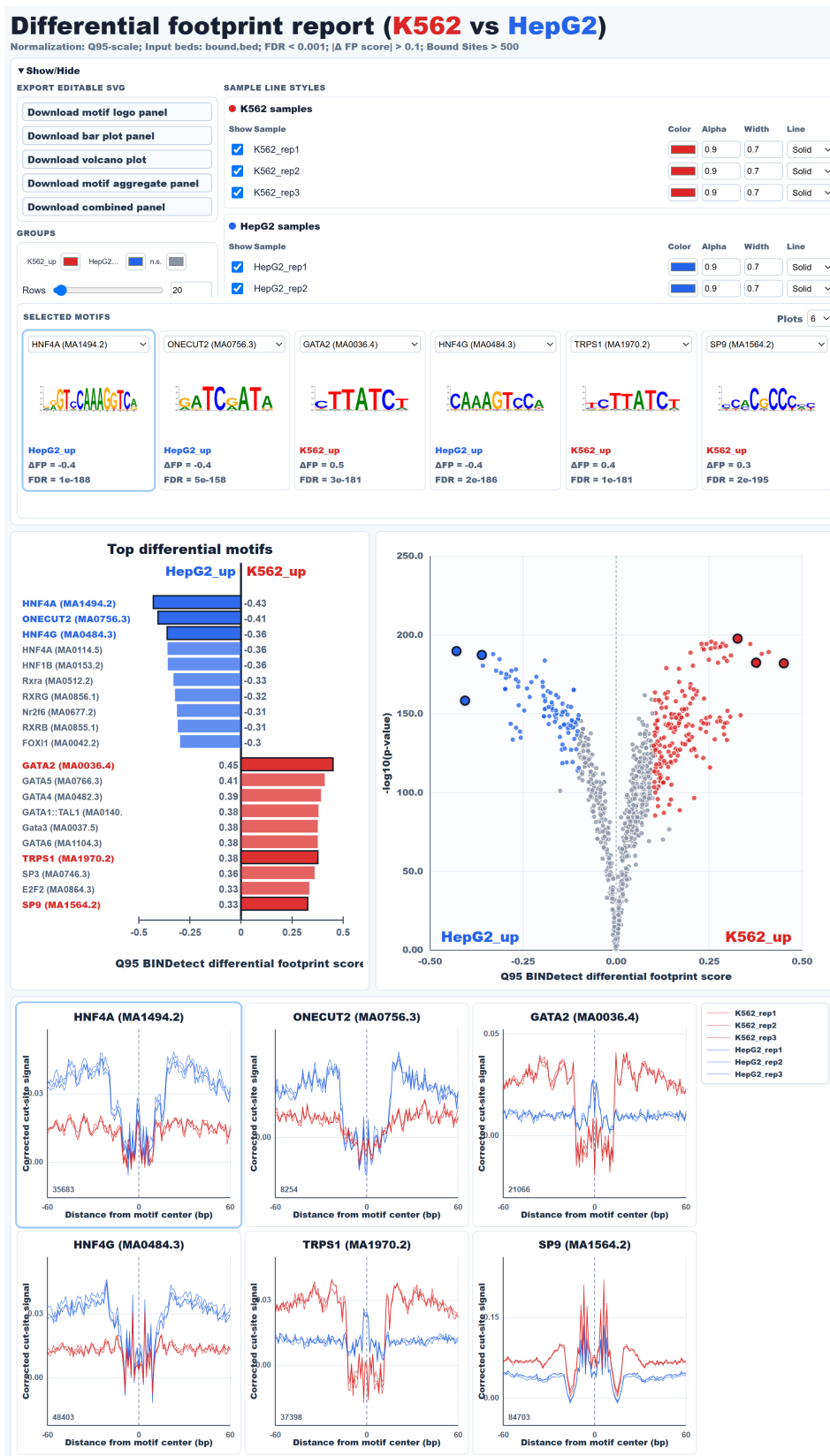
### 3.6. Single-cell ATAC Fragments Support Pseudobulk Footprinting

We evaluated pseudobulk aggregation using the public 10x Genomics 5k PBMC single-cell ATAC dataset [22]. The demonstration used the Cell Ranger ATAC 2.0.0 fragment file for `atac_pbmc_5k_nextgem` and broad cell annotations from the PBMC5k single-cell embedding. After filtering, 4,437 annotated cells were grouped into B cells (422 cells), monocytes (1,702 cells), and T/NK cells (2,313 cells). All three groups passed the pseudobulk filters and contained 2.1, 10.8, and 13.3 million counted fragments, respectively.



**Figure 2.** De novo motif discovery and validation summary. (A) Candidate footprint or BED intervals are converted into centered FASTA sequences, analyzed with MEME/DREME/STREME, and summarized as motif tables and reports. (B) Merged site-window coverage compares shared and de novo-only motif-supported intervals in K562 and HepG2. (C,D) Representative K562 and HepG2 de novo motifs show footprint-like normalized cut-site aggregate profiles centered on motif instances.

The full pseudobulk-footprints route uses the grouped PBMC5k fragments to emit pseudo-paired BAMs, run atac-correct with zero read shifting, score corrected footprint tracks, and optionally run motif-aware diff-footprints and aggregate plotting. Raw CPM cut-site tracks provide QC and chromatin-context signal alongside corrected footprint scores. Compared with preparing pseudobulk inputs outside the footprinting analysis and then running TOBIAS, fp-tools records barcode grouping, pseudobulk QC, correction, footprint scoring, motif-aware comparison, and aggregate plotting in one analysis



**Figure 3.** Interactive differential footprint report for K562 versus HepG2. The browser report view summarizes selected differential motifs, motif logos, top differential footprint-score bar plots, a volcano plot, and replicate-level motif-centered aggregate profiles. Blue indicates HepG2-biased footprint scores and red indicates K562-biased footprint scores.

route. This pseudobulk analysis is complementary to established single-cell chromatin-accessibility ecosystems such as ArchR and Signac and to motif-activity baselines such as chromVAR [23–25].

The same PBMC5k pseudobulk footprint table was used to prioritize marker TFs for cell-level visualization. We summarized the three broad-cell pairwise comparisons as volcano plots and labeled predeclared marker TFs from the two cell types in each comparison only when the differential-footprint direction matched the expected lineage direction. We then projected KNN-smoothed footprint-signature scores onto the PBMC5k UMAP. For each cell, the displayed value summarizes local motif-centered cut-site profiles in neighboring cells. The final figure combines a marker-by-cell heatmap with UMAP panels for broad cell-type labels and representative regulatory programs: B-cell-associated cytokine-response and AP-1 activation signatures, monocyte myeloid/interferon/inflammatory signatures, and T/NK-associated cytotoxic, tolerance-like, and TGF- $\beta$  regulatory-state signatures (Figure 4).

### 3.7. Evaluation and Figure Reproducibility

The manuscript analyses are linked to public inputs through manifests, schema checks, recorded command settings, and figure-generation scripts. Together, these files make the bulk, de novo, pseudobulk, replicate-aware, and report examples traceable from input data to final figures, while preserving the sample, motif, region, and signal-track choices used for each analysis.

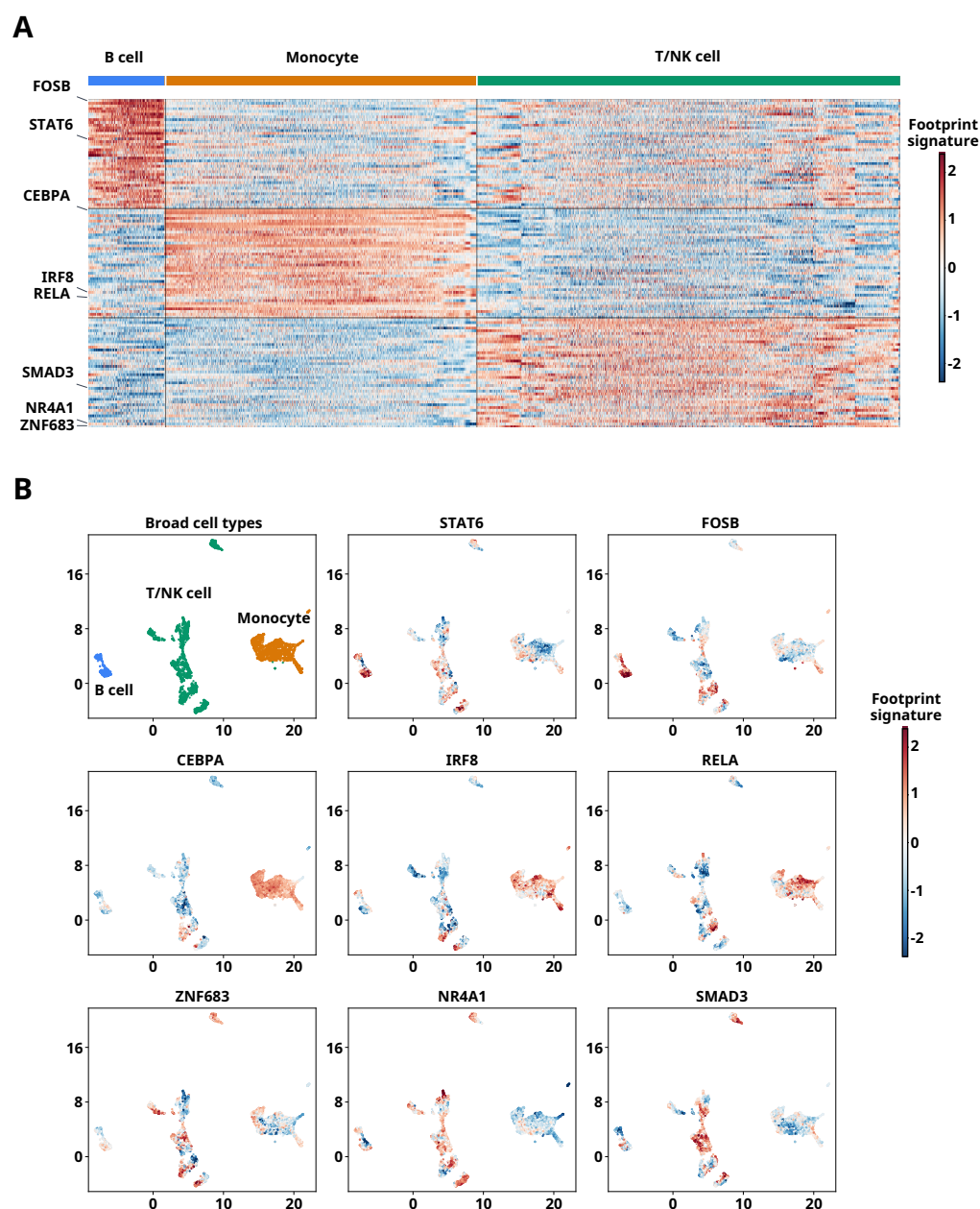
For each analysis, the workflow writes resolved manifests, software versions, parameters, and plotting tables beside the generated outputs. We also recorded runtime and peak memory for a single-machine comparison of TOBIAS and fp-tools using the same input bundle and command outputs (Figure 5). The browser GUI follows the same command structure and provides example loading, YAML review, run history, and report inspection for users who prefer a graphical workflow (Figure 6).

## 4. Discussion

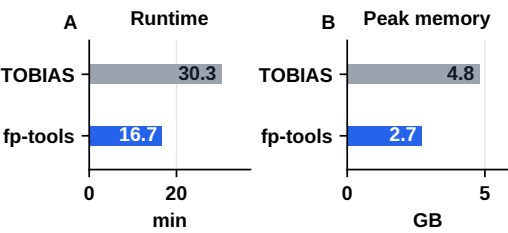
fp-tools extends motif-centered ATAC-seq footprinting by focusing on the analysis steps that often determine whether a footprinting result is easy to reproduce and interpret. The package keeps bias correction, footprint scoring, differential footprint analysis, aggregate visualization, de novo motif preparation, pseudobulk aggregation, and report generation under one command structure (Table 1). This is useful in practice because these steps are commonly split across custom scripts, separate motif tools, and manual plotting notebooks.

The closest comparison is TOBIAS, which established a widely used ATAC footprinting workflow for bias correction, footprint scoring, motif-aware differential analysis, and aggregate visualization. fp-tools builds on that interpretable bias-corrected center-versus-flank signal model while adding faster core operations, clearer command names, reusable YAML runs, SVG and HTML reports, explicit replicate-aware reporting, de novo motif-preparation support, pseudobulk single-cell analysis, a browser GUI, and tested public-data examples.

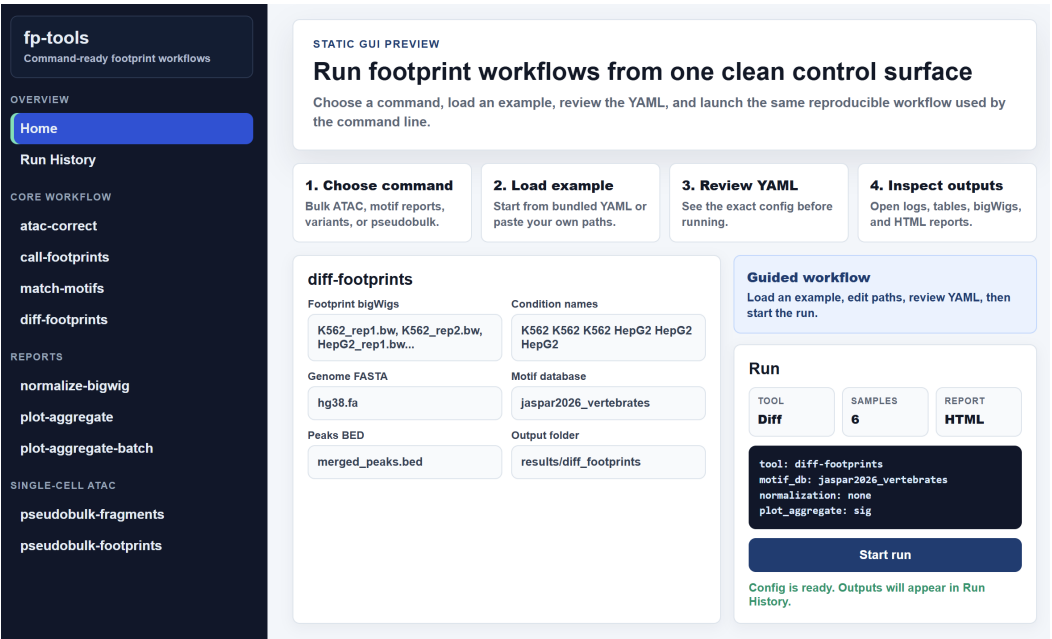




**Figure 4.** Single-cell footprinting summary in public PBMC5k single-cell ATAC data. **(A)** KNN-smoothed per-cell footprint-signature heatmap for top cell-type-specific motif signatures across B cells, monocytes, and T/NK cells; the TF rows used for Panel B are labelled on the left. **(B)** UMAP projections show broad cell-type annotations and representative motif-associated footprint-signature z-scores. B-cell-associated signatures include STAT6, consistent with IL-4-responsive humoral and class-switch-related signaling, and FOSB/AP-1, consistent with an activation-responsive immediate-early regulatory program. Monocyte-associated signatures include CEBPA, consistent with a C/EBP-family myeloid differentiation program; IRF8, consistent with monocyte/dendritic-cell and interferon-regulatory activity; and RELA, consistent with NF- $\kappa$ B-mediated inflammatory activation. T/NK-associated regulatory-state signatures include ZNF683/Hobit, consistent with a cytotoxic or resident-like program; NR4A1/Nur77, consistent with TCR-response and tolerance-like regulation; and SMAD3, consistent with TGF- $\beta$  regulatory signaling. TF labels indicate motif-associated footprint signatures rather than direct TF-specific occupancy.



**Figure 5.** Single-machine runtime and memory check. (A) Runtime and (B) peak memory are summarized for one local analysis run comparing TOBIAS and fp-tools on the same analysis bundle. These measurements are included as an engineering check, not as an exhaustive cross-tool benchmark.



**Figure 6.** Browser GUI for command-compatible footprinting analyses. The GUI provides sidebar access to core commands, guided configuration panels, example loading, YAML preview, run-history review, and report/output inspection and saves reusable YAML configurations that can also be run from the command line.

**Table 1.** Qualitative scope comparison across widely used ATAC-seq regulatory-analysis tools. ✓, documented native support; ○, partial, indirect, or adjacent support; NA, outside the tool’s primary scope. The table summarizes analysis scope from public documentation and primary publications; it is not a performance benchmark and should be read with the different goals of each tool in mind. TOBIAS is the closest core footprinting comparator; the fp-tools column emphasizes added analysis and usability components around that motif-centered model.

| Feature                           | fp-tools | TOBIAS | HINT-ATAC | PRINT/scPrinter | ChromBPNet | max ATAC |
|-----------------------------------|----------|--------|-----------|-----------------|------------|----------|
| Bulk ATAC footprinting            | ✓        | ✓      | ✓         | ✓               | ○          | NA       |
| Tn5 bias correction               | ✓        | ✓      | ✓         | ✓               | ✓          | NA       |
| Footprint calling                 | ✓        | ✓      | ✓         | ✓               | NA         | NA       |
| Motif-aware differential analysis | ✓        | ✓      | ○         | ○               | NA         | NA       |
| De novo motif preparation         | ✓        | NA     | NA        | ✓               | ○          | NA       |
| scATAC/pseudobulk support         | ✓        | ○      | ○         | ✓               | ○          | ○        |
| Replicate-aware reporting         | ✓        | ○      | ○         | ○               | NA         | NA       |
| Visualization/reporting           | ✓        | ✓      | ○         | ✓               | ✓          | ○        |
| YAML/batch execution              | ✓        | NA     | NA        | NA              | NA         | NA       |

Other regulatory-analysis tools address related but distinct questions. Deep sequence-to-profile models such as ChromBPNet learn sequence determinants of chromatin profiles and are well suited for occupancy and variant-effect analyses [10]. Accessibility-based frameworks such as diffTF estimate differential TF activity from changes in open chromatin [26]. These approaches are complementary to motif-centered footprinting rather than direct replacements. In this landscape, fp-tools is intended as an accessible, reproducible route from ATAC-seq cut-site signal to motif-level footprint interpretation.

## 5. Conclusions

We presented fp-tools as a Python platform for efficient, user-accessible ATAC-seq footprint analysis across bulk and single-cell-derived pseudobulk data. The examples show that an integrated command line, GUI, report system, and reproducible figure workflow can make TF footprint analysis more transparent without changing the core biological interpretation of motif-centered ATAC-seq footprints. Future work will focus on larger controlled cross-tool benchmarks and expanded validation across additional tissues, conditions, and replicate designs.

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**Informed Consent Statement:** Not applicable.

**Data Availability Statement:** fp-tools is openly available in the public GitHub repository [oncologylab/fp-tools](https://github.com/oncologylab/fp-tools). The repository contains the manifests, schemas, analysis scripts, figure generators, source tables, and small result tables used in this manuscript. Public input data are obtained from the ENCODE Project [18], the 10x Genomics PBMC5k single-cell ATAC example [22], and motif databases such as JASPAR [14] using the included download and preparation scripts. The computational environment is documented in `environment.yml` and the repository Dockerfile.

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**Conflicts of Interest:** The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Appendix

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**Table S1.** Primary analysis parameters used for the public ATAC and pseudobulk workflows. The complete source table is provided in the Supplementary Materials as “Primary analysis parameters”.

| Step                                 | Parameters                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Public input data                    | Bulk ATAC analyses use public ENCODE K562/HepG2 replicate BAMs and tracks. The pseudobulk single-cell demonstration uses the public 10x Genomics 5k PBMC scATAC fragment dataset. Motif analyses use JASPAR 2026 CORE vertebrate non-redundant motifs.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| ENCODE BAM processing                | Released GRCh38 alignment BAMs for K562 ENCSR868FGK and HepG2 ENCSR291GJU were filtered to standard chromosomes, indexed, and summarized before footprint analysis.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Blacklist and peak set               | Mitochondrial and nonstandard contigs excluded; hg38 blacklist v2 regions subtracted; released ENCODE peak intervals sorted and merged across replicates into one analysis peak set.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Bias correction and footprint scores | atac-correct run on filtered BAMs with merged peaks and blacklist regions using default Tn5-bias settings; corrected cut-site tracks q95-scaled over shared background regions for multi-sample analyses; call-footprints -score footprint run with default footprint and flank windows.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Differential footprint analysis      | The 3-vs-3 ENCODE K562/HepG2 replicate footprint tracks were analyzed with repeated condition labels, JASPAR 2026 motifs, and replicate reporting enabled. One-sample contrasts use motif-site versus background-distribution comparison; replicate-supported analyses use empirical-Bayes variance moderation on per-sample aggregated motif scores. ENCODE K562/HepG2 candidate footprints exported as cell-line-level FASTA files with ±75 bp flanks; reciprocal STREME 5.5.9 runs used -dna -nmotifs 250; Tomtom 5.5.9 matched discovered motifs to JASPAR 2026; discovered motifs were scanned back into candidate intervals for motif-window overlap summaries and aggregate footprint review. |
| De novo motif validation             | Public 10x PBMC5k scATAC fragments grouped into broad B-cell, monocyte, and T-NK labels, retaining 4,437 annotated cells and requiring at least 300 cells and 50,000 fragments per group. The full pseudobulk-footprints route writes pseudo-BAMs, runs ATAC correction with zero read shifting for fragment-derived pseudobulk BAMs, and emits footprint-score tracks, motif-aware differential results, pairwise volcano plots, and KNN-smoothed footprint-signature UMAPs.                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Pseudobulk PBMC analysis             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |

**Table S2.** Software and resource versions used for manuscript analyses. The complete source table is provided in the Supplementary Materials as “Software and resource versions”.

| Tool or resource               | Version            | Role                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| bedtools                       | 2.31.1             | Region sorting, merging, and blacklist subtraction                                                                              |
| Biopython                      | 1.87               | Sequence and motif-related utilities                                                                                            |
| Cell Ranger ATAC               | 2.0.0              | Source processing for the public 10x PBMC5k scATAC dataset                                                                      |
| fp-tools                       | 0.1.7              | ATAC correction, footprint calling, motif matching, differential footprint analysis, pseudobulk utilities, and plotting helpers |
| hg38 blacklist                 | v2                 | Artifact-region filtering for processed bulk ATAC alignments                                                                    |
| hg38 reference genome          | GRCh38/hg38        | Sequence extraction and ATAC bias correction                                                                                    |
| htslib                         | 1.23.1             | SAM/BAM/VCF I/O backend used by samtools                                                                                        |
| JASPAR CORE vertebrates        | 2026 non-redundant | Known motif database for differential footprint analysis                                                                        |
| matplotlib                     | 3.10.9             | Manuscript figure rendering                                                                                                     |
| MEME Suite, STREME, and Tomtom | 5.5.9              | De novo motif discovery and discovered-motif matching                                                                           |
| NumPy                          | 2.4.6              | Numerical arrays and benchmark/figure calculations                                                                              |
| pandas                         | 2.3.3              | Tabular processing for benchmark, manifest, and figure builders                                                                 |
| pyBigWig                       | 0.3.25             | bigWig signal reading and writing                                                                                               |
| pysam                          | 0.23.3             | BAM and genomic interval I/O                                                                                                    |
| Python                         | 3.12.3             | Runtime for analyses, figure builders, and provenance extraction                                                                |
| samtools                       | 1.23.1             | Released ENCODE BAM filtering, indexing, and QC summaries                                                                       |
| SciPy                          | 1.17.1             | Statistical and interpolation utilities                                                                                         |

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